declared the killing of cows to be anti-Hindu, leading to the formation of numerous cow-protection societies that increasingly assumed anti-Muslim, anti-British and Hindu nationalist overtones. Here Dayananda and the religious revivalists were greatly assisted by the popular prints published by the aristocrat, artist and publisher Ravi Varma, born into a Koil Thampuran family which by tradition produced the consorts for the princesses of the royal family of Travancore. A talented artist in his own right, Varma set up a lithographic printing press in 1894 at the suggestion of the then Dewan of Travancore. As well as popularising prints of his own paintings the Varma press mass-produced colourful images of Hindu deities. It was not the first press to do so – similar presses had preceded him in Calcutta (Kolkata) and Poona (Pune) – but the effect was to make religious art accessible to the man and woman in the street for the first time and on a wide scale.

Dayananda Saraswati died in 1883 but his reimagined past resurfaced in the 1920s as part of the Freedom Struggle's efforts to reclaim Indian history from British colonial bias and, before that, from the triumphalism of Muslim historiography. It followed the discovery of the buried brick city of Mohenjo-Daro (see Chapter 2) and the dawning realisation that this was just part of a widespread urban and farming culture that predated India's known early history by fifteen thousand years and more.

The discovery of the Harappan Civilisation came as a godsend to the ideologues of the nascent Hindutva, or 'Hindu-ness', movement, an ultra-nationalist pressure group succinctly characterised by Professor Romila Thapar in a recent newspaper interview as 'a kind of syndicated Hinduism … borrowing from Western models to create an organised, ecclesiastically run religion which might be used politically in a fascistic way to deny India's traditional plurality'.[17] The man who coined that word Hindutva was